BELOW DECKS

LEXINGTON HAD A complement of 2,600 officers and men, berthed in generally spartan conditions. *Lexington* represented a step forward from earlier carriers in some respects, however, notably the comfort of its pilot's briefing room. Much space below deck was devoted to the stowage of aircraft. The operation of aircraft in the confined space of a ship inevitably led to accidents, such as gruesome encounters between men and propellers.



« Bridge indicators
The bridge is fitted with a range of instruments, including this wind speed and direction indicator and the equipment for the bridge officers to talk to other areas of the ship.

» Navigation bridge
High in the island superstructure, with slanted windows to reduce the glare, the navigation bridge was the main command center of the ship. The large device in the center of the bridge is the navigational radar monitor.



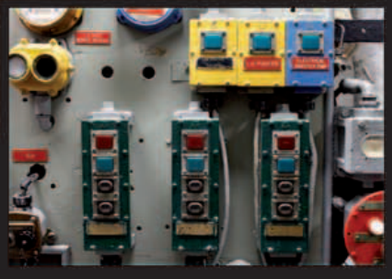
» Pilothouse
Situated behind the bridge, the pilothouse is where the ship would have been steered and its speed controlled. In the center of the room stand the engine order telegraph, helm wheel, and magnetic compass.



» Port engine control panel
Eight steam boilers powered the ship's four Westinghouse steam turbine engines. Control panels in each of the two engine rooms were used to control the turbine pressures and operate the engines.



» Engine control panel
Numerous dials, switches, and gauges were used to indicate the turbine pressures and operate the ship's engines.



» Pilot's ready room
The air-conditioned ready rooms were where pilots and air crew were briefed prior to their missions. Foldaway desks allowed the airmen to make notes during briefings.

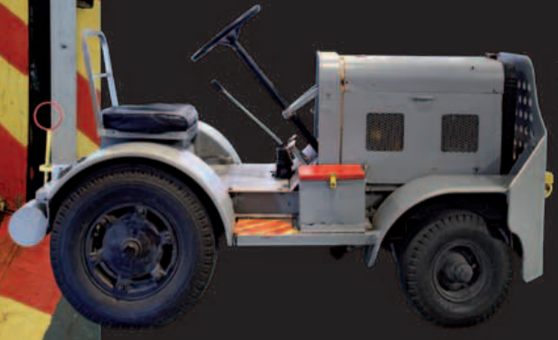




» Air Operations room
Planning and coordination for flight operations took place in the Air Ops room. The plot board listed all the day's flying schedules.



« Hangar division doors
Heavy hangar doors divided the main hangar into bays, helping to limit the damage from fired or explosions within individual bays. Each door section weighs over eight tons.



« Tow truck
With so many planes to move around the hangars, tow trucks were an indispensable piece of the ship's equipment.